as the CPI(M)'s Isaac, a native of coastal Kodungallur 150 km away, has "no roots in Pathanamthitta".

But then, Anil is no local either. Veteran politician and former seven-time MLA P.C. George, who joined the BJP recently, said as much—"No one knows him...". A section of district-level party leaders are also said to be upset over the "import". Anil's campaign is focusing on the Hindu women and youth in the constituency, and he has been busy visiting temples and doing pujas. But is it enough to connect with the Hindu voters, who make up 54 per cent of the electorate?

Congress candidate Anto Antony seems more assured about winning. But his victory margins have also been dipping steadily, from 111,205 votes in 2009 to 44,243 votes in 2019. "I've been with the people of the constituency since day one, and I'm ready to be judged by my past record. Neither the CPI(M) nor the BJP pose a threat, as they have no credibility," says Anto. He's still upset, though, that mentor A.K. Antony hasn't yet come to campaign for him in Pathanamthitta.

The CPI(M)'s Dr Isaac started the campaign early and has completed two rounds. He says the people want a change. "They are backing the LDF to raise their grievances in Parliament. My attempt is to meet the maximum number of people and convince them on why they should vote for the Left. The response has been very positive," he says.

State health minister Veena George, who contested the seat in 2019 and lost, says things have changed since. For one, all seven assembly constituencies in Pathanamthitta are now with the Left Front after the 2021 assembly polls. She also brushes aside reports of the church backing the BJP. "It's just a story floated by them. And even if the church leaders go with the BJP, the laity will not. We have fielded our most articulate and informed candidate in Pathanamthitta. I have no doubt we'll win," she says. Will the lotus bloom, though? ■

THE OBC PUSHBACK

A new political outfit aims to take on Maratha candidates in 18 out of the 48 Lok Sabha seats to secure socio-political space for OBCs

By Dhaval S. Kulkarni

Caste is back to stir the political pot in Maharashtra, with leaders from the Other Backward Class (OBC) groups launching their own party ahead of the Lok Sabha election. Named the OBC Bahujan Party, it plans to put up candidates in 18 of the 48 parliamentary seats in the state in a bid to challenge what its leaders claim to be the dominance of the Marathas in Maharashtra's polity.

The Marathas and OBCs have historically competed for social and political space in the state. But the immediate trigger here is the Maratha quota stir launched by activist Manoj Jarange-Patil, the resultant violence targeted at OBC leaders, and the Eknath Shinde-led government's decision to facilitate the extension of the 27 per cent OBC quota to those Marathas who can prove their lineage from Kunbis (peasants or tillers) besides a separate 10 per cent reservation for the community in jobs and education.

"The OBCs are incensed at Maratha attempts to corner their share of reservations," says former Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) legislator Prakash Shendge, who now heads the fledgling



FORCE MULTIPLIER
Prakash Shendge, president, OBC Bahujan Party